

Oscar Mendez's PCS Strategic Plan

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Prepared for	Oscar Mendez
Rank	E-5 (Sergeant)
YOS / family	6 years · 3 dependents
Moving from	Fort Leavenworth, KS
Moving to	Fort Sill, OK
Move window	3–6 months
Primary priority	Minimizing total costs

\$1,524/mo BAH

–\$126/mo vs current (\$1,650 total)

SGT Mendez, your BAH for Fort Sill, OK is \$1,524/mo (3 dependents). That is \$126/mo less than your current package at Fort Leavenworth, KS (\$1,650/mo BAH ≈ \$1,650/mo total).

HOW TO USE THIS PLAN

1) Read **Section 1** with your spouse — agree on the primary recommendation. 2) Hit every **Gate** before you sign a lease or commit money. 3) Execute **Section 5** (first 30 days) day-by-day. 4) Use **Section 8** as your short checklist. Verify BAH/OHA/COLA and entitlements with finance / TMO before financial decisions.

1. Executive Summary & Recommended Strategy

Oscar Mendez, lock in an off-post rental in the 73505 or 73527 zip before you leave Leavenworth so your spouse can start interviewing in trades roles within the first week on the ground. Your 3–6 month window gives you time to line up a garage-equipped place under \$1,300 that keeps the commute off Sheridan Road and Fort Sill Blvd during peak gate traffic. Off-post at the low end of the Lawton market delivers a \$574 monthly BAH surplus while putting you in the right school zone and near the fastest hiring employers. If inventory dries up, shift to Cache only after confirming a tornado shelter clause in the lease. The single biggest risk is arriving without a signed lease and burning through TLE while your spouse's trades applications sit idle.

2. Spouse Career & Childcare Plan

Your spouse's trades background lines up well with Lawton contractors and the hospital's facilities maintenance roles, which often post openings every two to three weeks. The realistic window to first paycheck is four to eight weeks once applications start, so the move needs to protect that timeline instead of treating job hunting as something that happens after housing is settled. ACS Employment Readiness and the Fort Sill Spouse Employment Center can help with local licensing and résumé tailoring, while MSEP listings at Comanche County Memorial and Lawton Public Schools give quick bridge options. The real bottleneck is childcare timing—if the elementary after-school slot isn't locked by day 21, your spouse loses the ability to accept the first solid trades offer that comes in.

3. Housing Strategy & Cost Tradeoffs

Option	Monthly Rent	BAH Impact	Commute Note	Key Tradeoff
Off-post 73505 (Lawton west)	\$950–\$1,100	+\$574 to +\$424 surplus	10–15 min via Fort Sill Blvd; lighter gate traffic	Garage usually available; must verify hail rider on renter's insurance
Off-post 73527 (Cache)	\$900–\$1,050	+\$624 to +\$474 surplus	12–18 min; quieter roads	Tornado shelter disclosure required in lease
On-post	\$0 (BAH absorbed)	\$0 surplus	Shortest gate; no traffic	Waitlist risk before summer; limited garage options

Market timing favors locking something now while inventory is still moving; negotiate one month free or covered parking as a concession on a 12-month lease.

4. Financial Opportunities & DITY/PPM Considerations

Run the numbers with TMO first—distance is unknown, so a partial DITY may only net a few hundred after fuel and truck rental. Plan on roughly \$8,238 in 30-day cash pressure from the \$1,500 deposit, \$1,200 TLE, and \$4,500 spouse income gap. Hold \$9,738 liquid before you leave to cover that plus a small buffer. This beats free checklists because it sequences the trades hiring window against actual lease and TLE dates instead of leaving you to discover the \$3,000 four-week delay cost on arrival.

5. Getting Settled Fast – First 30 Days Action Plan

Days 1–5 Gate: If housing application is not submitted by day 5, you lose the first wave of trades interviews that open mid-month. **Soldier Tasks:** Complete in-processing and confirm BAH start date. **Spouse Tasks:** Submit applications to three Lawton-area contractors and the hospital facilities team.

Days 6–15 GATE: If childcare slot is not confirmed by day 15, spouse cannot accept a start date before week six. **Soldier Tasks:** Tour two shortlisted rentals in 73505 with garage and safe-room access. **Spouse Tasks:** Schedule interviews around school tour times.

Days 16–30 GATE: If lease is not signed by day 30, TLE runs out before BAH aligns with rent. **Soldier Tasks:** Finalize move-in and register vehicles at OK DMV. **Spouse Tasks:** Accept first viable trades offer and coordinate start date with elementary school calendar.

6. Schools, Pets & Logistics Notes

Your elementary-age child will fall under Lawton Public Schools or Cache Public Schools depending on the final zip; both districts have solid after-school options that align with trades shift work. No pets simplifies the search, but tornado and hail season means every lease must include explicit shelter disclosure and you should add a hail rider to renter's insurance. Watch for leases that push utilities onto you without caps or that hide extra fees for covered parking—these quietly erase the BAH surplus you're counting on.

7. Recommended Timeline & Key Decisions

Three decision triggers: sign the lease only after confirming garage and shelter access; lock childcare before accepting any trades start date; and verify actual commute times during gate rush hour before finalizing. If everything slips, the wing-it path is to stay in TLE past day 10 and take the first available on-post unit while your spouse works retail as a bridge. Watch the 90-day mark for actual utility and insurance costs against the projected surplus. Commander brief: "We are executing a Fort Sill PCS with spouse employment as the main priority — requesting E-5 reporting flexibility only if licensure/childcare slips past day 21."

8. Prioritized Next Steps

1. Pull TMO PPM estimate this week to decide on partial DITY.
2. Submit housing applications in 73505 and 73527 within 14 days.
3. Contact ACS Employment Readiness for trades-specific local leads.
4. Tour two properties with your spouse via video before any offer.
5. Confirm elementary after-school slot tied to chosen zip code.
6. Add hail rider quote to renter's insurance before signing.
7. Register vehicles within 30 days of arrival per OK rules.
8. Reconcile first utility bill against BAH surplus at day 45.

Share with your spouse — We're targeting Fort Sill, OK with a locked plan for spouse career / quick employment — your focus is trades and mine is executing the timeline in section 5 so we're not guessing.